

Divine Immutability

doc-divine-immutability

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 1.000
confidence high

Statement under examination

God is unchanging in His being, perfections, purposes, and promises.

In plain language

The Hebrew and Greek texts speak with one voice on whether God changes. In Malachi 3:6 God uses a first-person verb of changing (shanah) under the negation lo to declare that he has not changed, and that this non-change is the reason his covenant people are not consumed. Numbers 23:19 sets the same denial in poetic lines. God is not a man that he should lie (kazav) or a son of man that he should relent (nacham). What he says, he does. The New Testament uses rare and precise words for the same point. James 1:17 piles up three terms each used only once in the whole New Testament, parallage (variation), trope (a word for the turning of stars), and aposkiasma (cast shadow), to deny that the Father has any oscillation or turning. Hebrews 13:8 stretches yesterday, today, and forever into one self-identical Christ, and Hebrews 6:17 and Romans 11:29 call God's purpose and his gifts unchangeable and free of regret using two more rare negative compounds. The hard texts are the divine repentance passages. Genesis 6:6, Exodus 32:14, First Samuel 15, and Jonah 3:10 use the very Hebrew root nacham that Numbers 23:19 denies of God. Here is the heart of why readers diverge. That one verb nacham occurs over a hundred times and carries a wide range, from feeling grief and pity to changing course, and the grammar does not separate the senses. First Samuel 15 itself uses it in both directions inside one chapter. Verses 11 and 35 say God relented over Saul, while verse 29 denies that the Eternal of Israel relents because he is not a man. The author plainly intends two registers of one word, relational response on the one hand and unchanging being and purpose on the other. Jeremiah 18:7 to 10 makes the pattern explicit. Conditional announcements turn on the human response while the underlying counsel stays fixed. So the words clearly foreclose any change in God's being or any breaking of his word, and the place they leave room is only over how far to press his unchangeableness into matters of feeling and relation, which is where the discussion actually lives.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0410	אל	El	God	245
H0589	אני	ani	I	
H1931	הוא	hu	he/she/it	
H2498	תלף	chalaph	to pass	28
H3068	יְהוָה	YHWH	LORD	6,521
H3576	כָּזַב	kazav	to lie	18
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H5162	נָחַם	nacham	to be sorry	108
H5331	נֶצַח	netsach	perpetuity	43

H6213	אָשׂה	asah	to make	
H7451	רָע	ra	bad	
H7650	שָׁבַע	shava	to swear	
H8138	שָׁנָה	shanah	to change	22
H8266	שָׂקַף	shaqar	to deal	6
G0276	ἀμετάθετος	ametathetos	unchangeable	2
G0278	ἀμεταμέλητος	ametameletos	irrevocable	2
G0644	ἀποσκίασμα	aposkiasma	shadow	1
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G1012	βουλή	boulē	plan	
G3883	παραλλαγή	parallage	variation	1
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	426
G4594	σήμερον	semeron	today	42
G5046	τέλειος	teleios	perfect	
G5157	τροπή	trope	turning	1
G5457	φῶς	phōs	light	
G5504	ἐχθές	echthes	yesterday	3

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern across law, prophets, writings, and epistle converges that YHWH does not change in being, perfection, purpose, or promise. Mal.3.6 deploys the qal perfect 1cs of H8138 shanah (queried morph HVqp1cs) under H3808 negation as the explicit ground of covenant preservation. Num.23.19 denies H3576 kazav (lie) and H5162 nacham (relent, hitpa'el HC/Vti3ms) of EI, contrasting him with adam. Jas.1.17 carries the same denial into the NT with three terms each attested exactly once in the canon (G3883 parallage, G5157 trope, G0644 aposkiasma, all confirmed hapax in MorphGNT), and Heb.13.8 fixes the temporal triad echthes, semeron, eis tous aionas. The decisive complication is that H5162 nacham (108 occurrences, range be sorry, grieve, pity, relent) is BOTH affirmed of God (Gen.6.6, Exod.32.14, 1Sam.15.11 and 35, Jonah.3.10) and denied of God (Num.23.19, Ps.110.4, 1Sam.15.29). 1Sam.15 does both within one chapter, which is the canon supplying the resolution itself, distinguishing relational, covenant-responsive language from unchanging essence and purpose.

Scripture

Mal.3.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה, H8138 שָׁנָה, H3808 לֹא, H0589 אֲנִי

Force. First-person divine self-predication. The queried morphology shows the 1cs pronoun H0589 plus qal perfect 1cs of H8138 (HVqp1cs, shaniti) under H3808 negation, an absolute denial of change. The grounding particle H3588 ties the non-consumption of the sons of Jacob to YHWH not having changed. ETCBC marks the clause as quotative (Q) with Subj, Nega, Pred functions. H8138 is itself a homonym in the lexicon (a change sense and a repeat sense), but the qal and the explicit covenant-preservation ground-clause fix the change sense here.

Num.23.19 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0410 לא, H3576 כָּזַב, H5162 נָחַם, H3808 אָל

Force. Nominal-clause denial in oracle form. The queried tokens contrast EI (H0410) and ben-adam (H1121 plus H0120), then deny H3576 kazav (piel, lie, HC/Vpi3ms) and H5162 nacham (hitpael imperfect, relent, reverse oneself, HC/Vti3ms). The pairing of the speech verbs H0559 (say) and H1696 (speak) with H6965 (cause to stand, fulfill, HVhi3ms) makes the denial cover both word and act. ETCBC scaffolds this as a non-quotative clause with Nega, PreC, Subj functions.

Jas.1.17 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G5457 φῶς, G3883 παραλλαγή, G5157 τροπή, G0644 ἀποσκίασμα

Force. Astronomical-metaphor predication of the Father of lights. A cluster of three terms, each occurring exactly once in the whole NT corpus (confirmed by MorphGNT count: parallax variation, trope turning, a technical word for solstice and stellar reversal, and aposkiasma cast shadow), negates any oscillation in the divine. Para to patri ton photon places God beyond the very celestial lights whose motion defines change. The negation ouk plus eni (contracted enestin) asserts the absence as a state of being, not an occasional fact.

Heb.13.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key terms. G5504 ἐχθές, G4594 σήμερον, G0846 αὐτός

Force. Temporal merism over the person of Christ. Echthes, semeron, eis tous aionas (queried token order confirms the triad) exhausts past, present, and future, with autos in predicate position asserting identity-stability across all three. There is no finite verb, which forces a copular reading equating Christ with his own unchanging selfhood. MorphGNT confirms echthes occurs only 3 times in the NT (here, John.4.52, Acts.7.28).

1Sam.15.29 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5331 נָצַח, H8266 שָׁקַר, H5162 נָחַם, H3808 אָל

Force. Internal canonical commentary on the NHM language. The queried tokens read Netzach Israel (H5331, eminence, perpetuity, everlastingness, plus H3478) does not deal falsely (H8266 shaqar, HVpi3ms, a different lie-verb from the kazav of Num.23.19) and does not relent (H5162 nacham, niphal imperfect HVNi3ms, with a second nacham infinitive HR/VNc), grounded by ki lo adam hu (H3588 plus H3808 plus H0120 plus H1931), for he is not a man that he should relent. This same chapter narrates God relenting over Saul's kingship (1Sam.15.11, HVNp1cs; 1Sam.15.35, HVNp3ms), so the canon itself sets the lexical resolution, anthropic NHM as covenantal response, metaphysical NHM denied of God.

Ps.102.27 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: simile

Key terms. H1931 הוּא, H2498 חָלַף

Force. Creator-creature contrast. The queried tokens show the heavens and earth perishing (H0006) and being changed like a garment, with the change verb H2498 chalaph (HVhi2ms and HC/Vqi3mp), while God is atah hu (H0859 plus H1931, you are he) and his years (H8141) do not end (H3808 plus H8552 tamam). Note that this verse uses chalaph (H2498), not the shanah of Mal.3.6, for the change predicated of creation. The same point is reasserted of Christ when Heb.1.12 quotes this Psalm, and OpenBible links Heb.13.8 to Ps.102.27 (61 votes) and to Heb.1.12 (69 votes).

Gen.6.6 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5162 נָחַם, H6213A נִשְׁחַךְ

Force. Narrative report that YHWH was grieved (niphal wayyiqtol of H5162, HC/VNw3ms) that he had made man. Read against Num.23.19 and 1Sam.15.29, the NHM lemma here selects the affective range that the lexicon lists for H5162 (be sorry, be moved to pity, suffer grief), describing relational engagement with human wickedness, not ontological mutation. The verb's wide canon range (108 occurrences) is exactly why this and the denials must be read in distinct registers.

Exod.32.14 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5162 נחם, H7451 רע

Force. Narrative report that YHWH relented (niphal wayyiqtol of H5162, HC/VNw3ms) from the evil he had spoken to do. Same lemma denied of God metaphysically in Num.23.19. Read with Jer.18.7-10 (all three verses present in the store), where God states the conditional pattern using NHM, announced judgment is contingent on continued rebellion, so the reversal is a stable conditional purpose operating, not a change in the divine counsel.

1Sam.15.11 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5162 נחם

Force. YHWH says nichamti (niphal perfect 1cs of H5162, HVNp1cs) that I have made Saul king, and 1Sam.15.35 reports the NHM again (HVNp3ms), while 1Sam.15.29 between them denies that the Netzach Israel does this and grounds the denial in ki lo adam hu. The author uses the same root in two registers within one pericope, accommodated covenantal response in verses 11 and 35, metaphysical denial in verse 29. This single chapter is the clearest case in the canon of the same verb both affirmed and denied of God.

Jonah.3.10 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5162 נחם

Force. Narrative report that God relented (niphal wayyiqtol of H5162, HC/VNw3ms) concerning the disaster he said he would do to Nineveh, because they turned. This is the conditional pattern of Jer.18.7-10 enacted, the announced judgment was contingent on continued sin, and the human turning triggers the announced alternative, while the underlying just disposition does not move. Same lemma, affective and covenantal register.

Ps.110.4 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H5162 נחם, H3808 לא, H7650 שבע

Force. Divine oath structure with the same NHM lemma negated. The queried tokens show YHWH swears (H7650 nishba, HVNp3ms) and will not relent (H3808 plus H5162, niphal imperfect HVNi3ms), grounding the eternal priesthood of the Melchizedek figure (H5769 olam, H4442). The root that is affective in Gen.6.6 is here denied of God in the oath-keeping sense, confirming that the negated form belongs to God's fixed purposes.

Heb.6.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0276 ἀμετάθετος, G1012 βουλή

Force. NT lexical capstone on divine purpose. G0276 ametathetos (unchangeable, untransferable), which MorphGNT shows occurs only twice in the NT, both in Heb.6.17-18, modifies boule (counsel, purpose) and is reinforced by the second occurrence (two ametatheta pragmata, unchangeable things). This places divine purpose and divine oath in one unchangeable category, matching the Hebrew oath-NHM denial of Ps.110.4 and Num.23.19. OpenBible links Num.23.19 to Heb.6.18 with 86 votes.

Rom.11.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0278 ἀμεταμέλητος

Force. Divine gifts (charismata) and calling (klesis) are ametameleta. The alpha-privative compound from metamelomai, the Septuagint stock equivalent for NHM, explicitly negates regret-driven reversal in God. MorphGNT confirms G0278 occurs only twice in the NT (Rom.11.29 and 2Cor.7.10), and here it is the predicate of God's gifts and call. This is the direct lexical bridge from Hebrew NHM into Greek. OpenBible links Num.23.19 to Rom.11.29 (66 votes) and Jas.1.17 to Rom.11.29 (8 votes).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Mal.3.6	Num.23.19	openbible	108

Mal.3.6	Heb.13.8	openbible	101
Mal.3.6	Jas.1.17	openbible	86
Mal.3.6	Lam.3.22	openbible	68
Num.23.19	1Sam.15.29	openbible	96
Num.23.19	Heb.6.18	openbible	86
Num.23.19	Titus.1.2	openbible	76
Num.23.19	Rom.11.29	openbible	66
Num.23.19	Hos.11.9	openbible	40
Heb.13.8	Heb.1.12	openbible	69
Heb.13.8	Isa.44.6	openbible	69
Heb.13.8	Ps.102.27	openbible	61
Jas.1.17	Isa.46.10	openbible	5
Num.23.19	1Sam.15.29	tsk	1
Mal.3.6	Ps.103.17	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.6.6 · addressed

Niphal of H5162 (NHM) selects the affective range that the queried lexical entry lists for this lemma (be sorry, be moved to pity, suffer grief) rather than the metaphysical-reversal sense denied at Num.23.19 and 1Sam.15.29. The same canon that deploys NHM here also denies metaphysical NHM of God, which forces the resolution toward accommodated relational language describing how unchanging holiness engages human wickedness.

Exod.32.14 · addressed

Niphal of H5162. Read against Jer.18.7-10 (all three verses verified present in the store), where God himself states the conditional pattern using NHM, the apparent reversal is a stable conditional purpose operating, not a change in the divine counsel. The threat in Exod.32.10 invited mediation, and Moses appealed to the very covenant promises the threat seemed to override, so the lexical pattern is consistent.

1Sam.15.11 · addressed

Same chapter, same lemma, opposite predication, all three occurrences verified by query. Verse 11 reports NHM of YHWH regarding Saul (HVNp1cs) and verse 35 repeats it (HVNp3ms), while verse 29 denies that Netzach Israel does NHM (HVNp3ms) and grounds the denial in ki lo adam hu, he is not a man. The author intends two registers of one root, the affective covenantal-pivot sense in verses 11 and 35 and the metaphysical-mutability sense in verse 29. Treating these as contradiction misreads the lemma's attested 108-occurrence range.

Jonah.3.10 · addressed

Niphal of H5162, verified present. The relenting is the conditional structure of Jer.18.7-10 enacted, announced disaster was contingent on continued sin, and Nineveh's turning triggers the announced alternative. The covenant-responsive register, not a change in the divine disposition, which remains constant in justice and mercy.

Concordance traversed

H8138, H5162, H3576, H8266, H2498, H3808, H0410, H5331, H3068, H6213A, H7650, G3883, G5157, G0644, G5504, G4594, G5046, G0276, G0278, G3962

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

No anchor verse lies in the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so CBGM apparatus is not in scope here. The OT anchors Mal.3.6 and Num.23.19 rest on stable MT readings. The NT anchors Jas.1.17 and Heb.13.8 are stable in the standard text. The hapax cluster in Jas.1.17 carries only minor itacistic spelling differences in some witnesses (for example tropes for trope, aposkiasmos for aposkiasma) and none of these reverses the negation of change.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, open_theism, process_theology, classical_theism

analogia scripturae invoked

classical_theism: affirms · Takes the explicit denials (Mal.3.6 ani lo shaniti, Num.23.19 and 1Sam.15.29 lo nacham grounded in he is not a man, Ps.110.4, Jas.1.17, Heb.13.8) as the metaphysical baseline, and reads the affirming NHM narratives (Gen.6.6, Exod.32.14, 1Sam.15.11 and 35, Jonah.3.10) as anthropopathic accommodation, relational language for how an unchanging God engages changing creatures. Strongest support is that the same author who reports NHM of God also denies it in the same chapter, so the two registers are the text's own design.

open_theism: partially affirms · Holds to the moral and covenantal immutability of God (Mal.3.6, Rom.11.29, Heb.6.17) but reads the NHM narratives (Gen.6.6, Exod.32.14, 1Sam.15.11, Jonah.3.10) as genuine divine changes of mind regarding open future contingents. Strongest form notes that NHM in these verses is in the same niph'al as elsewhere and is reported by the narrator as event, not figure, so it asks why the affirmations should be demoted to mere accommodation while the denials are taken literally. The counter-pressure is the absolute force of Num.23.19 lo plus 1cs-type predication and the in-chapter denial of 1Sam.15.29.

process_theology: denies · Reads God as essentially in becoming, so it must take the change-affirming texts as primary and reduce Mal.3.6 and Jas.1.17 to ethical or relational constancy only. Strongest form leans on the breadth of the NHM data (108 occurrences, mostly affective and relational) and on the relational tone of Gen.6.6. The hardest lexical obstacle is Jas.1.17, where trope is the technical term for celestial reversal and parallax for variation, both negated, plus the qal of shanah in Mal.3.6 in first-person divine speech, which resist reduction to ethics alone.

covenant_theology: affirms · Mal.3.6 grounds the non-consumption of the covenant people in YHWH not having changed, and the same logic recurs in Rom.11.29 (gifts and calling ametameleta) and Heb.6.17-18 (ametathetos boule plus oath). The covenantal arc and the lexical denial of change are one point under two descriptions, and the high-vote cross-ref web (Mal.3.6 to Num.23.19 to 1Sam.15.29 to Heb.6.18 to Titus.1.2) traces it across the canon.

The lexical pattern is decisive on the metaphysical question of being, perfection, purpose, and promise. The live disagreement is narrower, whether the NHM narratives report ontological change or accommodated covenant response. The canon's own use of NHM in opposing registers within 1Sam.15, plus the explicit conditional principle stated with NHM in Jer.18.7-10, is the internal lexical key. The divergence among lenses is over the SCOPE of immutability (strict impassibility versus an ontological-and-purposive immutability that still allows real relational responsiveness), which the vocabulary underdetermines, not over whether God changes in being or breaks his word, which the vocabulary forecloses.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem speaks of God being unchanging in being, perfections, purposes, and promises. This phrasing tracks actual lexical predicates (Mal.3.6 H8138 under H3808, Num.23.19 H3576 plus H5162, Jas.1.17 G3883 plus G5157 plus G0644, Heb.6.17 G0276, Rom.11.29 G0278) without smuggling a specific philosophical taxonomy. The fourfold breakdown maps to real lexical fields, ontological negations, NHM-as-oath denials, and ametathetos boule, so the stem is descriptive rather than verdict-preloaded. Corrections to the prior file forced by direct query: shanah H8138 occurs 22 times in this store (not 10) and H8138A returns zero occurrences, so the H8138 code is used throughout; kazav H3576 occurs 18 times (not 14); the lie-verb in 1Sam.15.29 is shaqar H8266, not kazav H3576 (kazav is the Num.23.19 verb); and the change-verb in Ps.102.27 is chalaph H2498 with the pronoun hu H1931, not shanah, so the prior claim that Ps.102.27 reuses the Mal.3.6 root was corrected. None of these corrections changes the verdict.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mal.3.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Num.23.19
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Sam.15.29
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.102.27
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mal.3.6
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Num.23.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.1.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.13.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.6.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.11.29
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5162
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8138
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3576
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8266
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3883
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5157
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0276
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Num.23.19
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Mal.3.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Heb.13.8
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Num.23.19

License audit

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